Before you begin

Alcohol: my diary and my life story

Keeping a diary

Buy a notebook or journal that you keep just for this programme. Start writing in it today, every day until your cohort begins, and keep going through the 33 days. You don't need to change anything yet: just notice, and write it down. Nobody else needs to read it.

Each time you have a drink, write down:

- The time, and where you are.
- What you are drinking, and how much.
- Whether you are alone, or who you are with.
- What you were doing just before.
- How you felt just before: stressed, tired, lonely, anxious, celebrating.
- How strong the urge was, from 0 to 5, and whether this drink would be easy or hard to skip.

At the end of each day, write a few lines:

- How many drinks did I have today?
- Which ones could I have let go of? Which felt hardest to skip, and why?
- What emotions sat underneath my drinking today?
- How did I feel while drinking, later that night, and the next morning?
- One thing I noticed about myself today.

My life story

Take your time with these. Write in your journal over a few days, as much or as little as feels right. There are no right answers: just be honest with yourself.

1. When did you have your first drink? How old were you, where were you, and who were you with?

2. What was happening in your life at that time?

3. How long have you been drinking regularly? How has it changed over the years: times you drank more, less, or stopped for a while?

4. What do you drink now, how much, and when: after work, at weekends, with food, alone?

5. What is alcohol a replacement for? What does it give you that you don't get another way: relaxation, confidence, connection, escape, sleep, a reward?

6. Which emotions most often lead you to drink: stress, boredom, loneliness, anxiety, anger, sadness, celebration?

7. Who in your family drank, or drinks? What did you learn about alcohol growing up?

8. What have you tried before to stop or cut down, and what did you learn from it?

9. What does alcohol cost you: your health, sleep, money, mornings, relationships, how you feel about yourself?

10. What has brought you to this group, now?

11. Who are you becoming? Describe a day in your life living alcohol-free.